

Note for Local Install Users

Read this first if you installed OpenClaw on your own machine

OpenClaw works exactly the same whether you install it on a VPS or on your own machine, and most of this course applies to both setups without any changes. There are just two small places where your path differs from what you see on screen, and this short guide is here to explain both of them so you never feel stuck. Read through it once at the start of the course, and you'll be set for the rest of the lessons.

The short version: Most of the course works exactly the same on local and VPS. There are only two situations where your steps differ from what you see on screen: accessing the gateway dashboard, and adding API keys. Everything else — model setup, skills, cron jobs, mini projects, Mission Control — works identically on both setups.

Difference #1 — Accessing the Gateway Dashboard

Whenever I show myself logging into the gateway dashboard through Hostinger (going to the Hostinger panel, copying the gateway token, clicking on OpenClaw, pasting the token), you don't need to do any of that. You have your dashboard running on your own machine, and you can access it directly in your browser at this URL:

`http://127.0.0.1:18789`

Bookmark that URL in your browser so you can get to your dashboard in one click whenever a lesson needs it. The dashboard will ask for your gateway token the first time, and after that it will remember you.

Can't remember your gateway token?

No problem. The easiest way to find it is just to ask your agent. Open your Telegram chat and send something like:

What is my gateway token?

Your agent will grab it for you in seconds. No digging through config files, no running commands. This is a great example of the golden rule of OpenClaw — tell your agent what you want, and let it handle the how.

Quick reminder: We covered this in more detail in the *Installing OpenClaw Locally* lesson. If you need a refresher on the dashboard URL or gateway token, check the PDF guide attached to that lesson.

Difference #2 — Adding API Keys

Several lessons in the course show me adding API keys (for Anthropic, OpenAI, OpenRouter, Gemini, and others) using the Hostinger Docker Manager. That's where VPS users store their environment variables. On a local install, you don't have a Docker Manager — but the process is actually simpler.

The easy way: just ask your agent

Whenever I say something like "open Hostinger Docker Manager and add a new environment variable called OPENROUTER_API_KEY", you just paste the key directly into your Telegram chat and ask your agent to handle it. The agent will add the key to your OpenClaw config and restart the gateway for you, all in one go.

Example prompt for adding any API key

Replace the variable name and model identifier with whatever the lesson is using:

Here is my API key: YOUR_KEY. Please add it to my OpenClaw config as VARIABLE_NAME, then configure the provider and set it up as described. Restart the gateway once you're done.

For example, for OpenRouter you'd use `OPENROUTER_API_KEY`, for Google Gemini you'd use `GEMINI_API_KEY`, for OpenAI you'd use `OPENAI_API_KEY`, and so on. The variable name is always the same as what I use in the lesson — only the path to adding it is different.

Cleaning up after setup

Once your agent confirms the setup is done, it's a good habit to ask it to scrub the key from memory:

Please remove my API key from your memory and don't keep a copy of it anywhere in your notes or logs. The key is already saved in the config, so you don't need to remember it.

Security tip: The original message where you pasted the key still exists in your Telegram chat history. For extra safety, you can manually delete that message in Telegram, or revoke the key on the provider website and create a new one after the setup is complete. For personal use and learning, this level of cleanup is plenty.

Your Local Install Cheat Sheet

Stick this on a note or bookmark this page for quick reference throughout the course:

When the lesson shows...	What you do instead
Logging into Hostinger dashboard	Open <code>http://127.0.0.1:18789</code> in your browser
Copying gateway token from Hostinger	Ask your agent "what is my gateway token"
Adding env variable in Docker Manager	Paste the key to your agent on Telegram
Clicking Save and Deploy	Agent restarts the gateway automatically
Waiting for container to restart	Agent handles the restart for you

One last thing: If you ever get confused about what to do in a lesson, just ask your agent. Something like "I'm on a local install and the lesson shows the Hostinger path, what do I need to do instead?" usually works really well. Your agent knows your setup and can walk you through the equivalent steps on your own machine.

OpenClaw Masterclass — Note for Local Install Users

Keep this guide handy throughout the course. You only need to read it once, but you can come back anytime.